

developed by others (not Google). An indication of the capability of the indexing engine is its ability to work even with password-protected Word and Excel documents. (This can also be seen as a good indicator of MS Office's privacy measures.)

Besides local folders, GDS can be set to index folders on other PCs on a network. The indexing is not a continuous process, and the user cannot set the frequency of indexing.

Google creates a folder called "Google Desktop Data" on the system without informing the user. This contains the indexes created by Google, and they can grow to large sizes. Since indexing is not continuous, it is possible that files that were deleted after the last indexing still appear in the search results. This can be avoided by setting the search to delete these results from the index. New files are automatically indexed, unless this option is turned off, so there is no need to manually re-index every time a new file is added.

By default, GDS uses a sidebar that also contains the search box. Besides search, the GDS sidebar acts as a docking area to add sub-applications that source data from the Net. These "sub-applications"—news tickers, weather forecasters, e-mail notifiers, etc.—can be added to the sidebar, and this content is constantly updated. GDS tracks the user's search habits to customise the content displayed in these sub-applications. This data collection from a private PC may seem intrusive to many. To address privacy concerns, Google does undertake that the data collected is not used in the identification of users.

GDS blurs the offline/online divide when it comes to offering answers, since after all it is the data that matters and not its location. GDS allows integration of a Gmail account, so a history of all searches can be



The GDS sidebar